Designing Systems for Adults 55+: Implementing Advant AGE LA to Employ, Retain, and Advance Workers



CWA Meeting of the Minds Conference
September 10, 2026

AGENDA

I. AdvantAGE LA: From Blueprint to Implementation

II. Success To Date: Strategies for Building an Age-Inclusive Workforce System

III. Group Activity

IV. Case Study

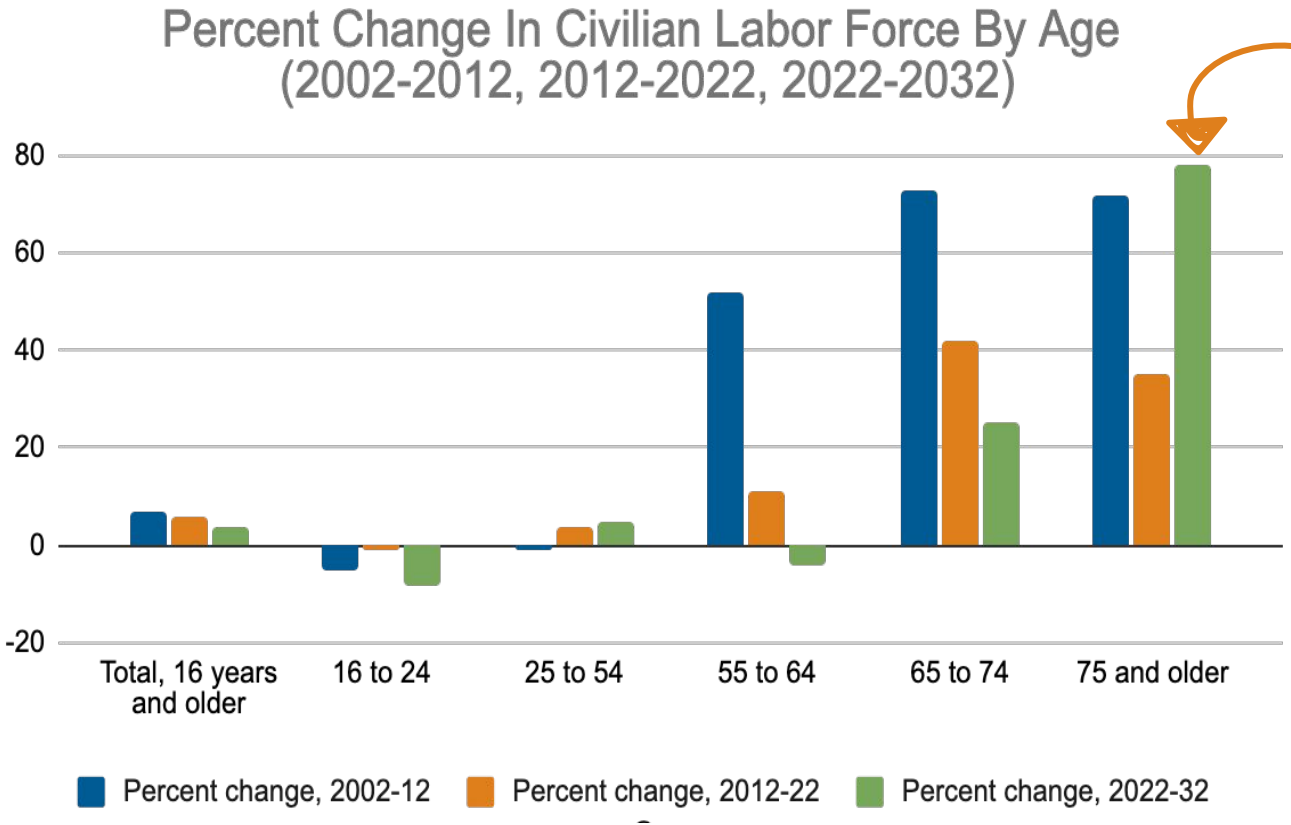
V. Lessons Learned and Recommendations

VI. Takeaways and Closing




NEED FOR A
55+ WORKER
STRATEGY

NEED FOR A 55+ WORKER STRATEGY



People 75+ in the labor force will grow ~80% from 2022-32

By 2035 those >65 will outnumber people <**18** for the first time in U.S. history.

BLS DATA

CHALLENGES FACED BY 55+ WORKERS

64% of 55+ Workers say they have seen or experienced age discrimination in the workplace (AARP)



Over 50% of workers over the age of 50 have experienced involuntary job separation.[5]

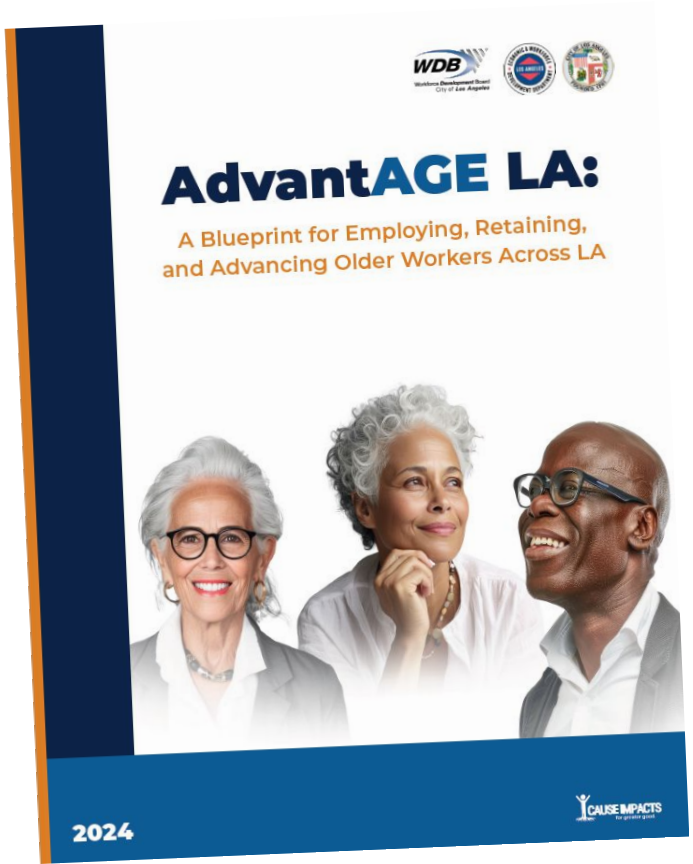


After separations, Older Workers are substantially **less likely to find new work** compared to people under 55.



Older Workers who find work typically **make 23–41% less** than they did in previous roles.[6]

2024 AdvantAGE LA Plan



INCLUDES:

- ✔ **Best practices** for employing, retaining, and advancing 55+ Workers
- ✔ **Strengths and challenges of current workforce programs** for 55+ Workers
- ✔ **Goals, Strategies, and Tactics for the City of Los Angeles**
- ✔ **Metrics to measure progress**

Plan was integrated into 5-year Strategic Plan and adopted by the Workforce Development Board and City Council.

STEERING COMMITTEE

We established a Steering Committee to improve coordination and collaboration across 55+ adult–serving systems including city, county, education, and training providers.

City

- Aging
- Community Investment
- Personnel
- Civil + Human Right
- Rec & Parks
- Housing

County

- Economic Opportunity
- Mature Worker COE

CBOs

- AARP CA
- Chrysalis
- Chinatown Service Center
- Goodwill SoCal

State

- CC Chancellor's Office
- Commission on Aging
- EDD

Industry

- LAEDC
- LA Chamber
- Hospital Association of SoCal

Education

- LA Community College District
- LAUSD Adult Ed.

Philanthropy

- Archstone Foundation

THE AdvantAGE LA PLAN

VISION: Los Angeles recognizes the economic and social value of 55+ Workers to the workforce, businesses, and communities and leverages their talent to advance economic vitality in the region.



GOAL 1: Improve Older Worker access to workforce support and success outcomes



GOAL 2: Increase the number of age-inclusive employers



GOAL 3: Establish the City as an age-inclusive employer



GOAL 4: Improve the responsiveness of the workforce system to Older Adults' needs



GOAL 5: Provide in-demand training and career advancement pathways


SUCCESSES
TO DATE

ACCOUNTABILITY: TRACKING DATA

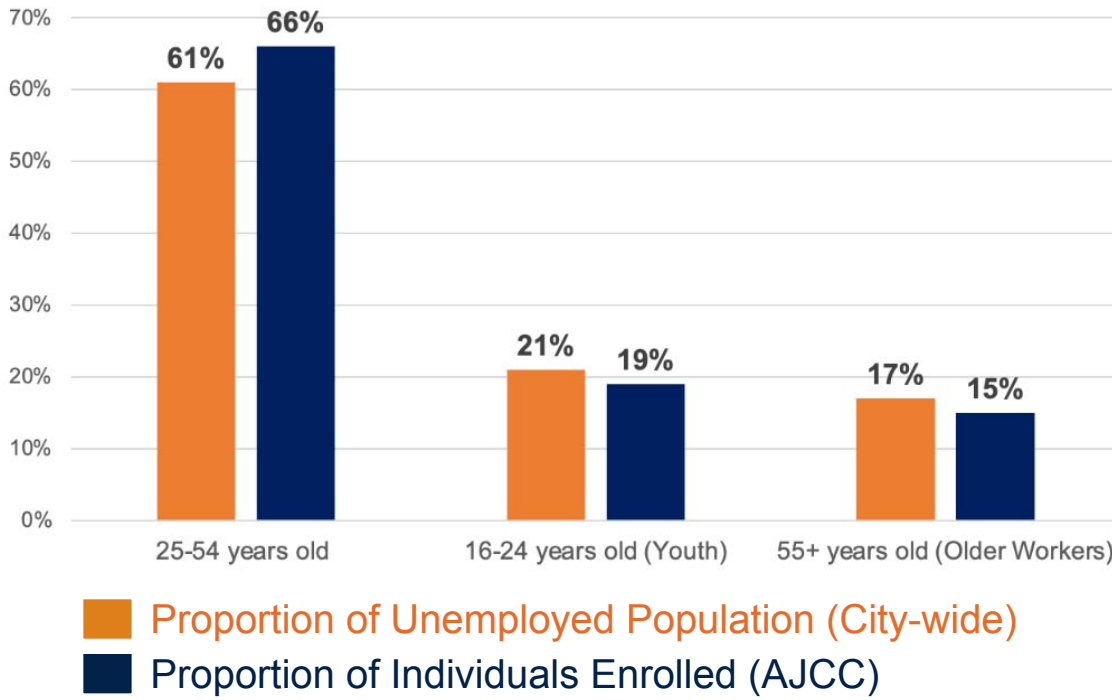
GOAL 1

In LA City, 17.6% of unemployed are 55+,

but only 15% of those enrolled in our AJCCs were 55+.

Created a local performance metric to serve a proportional # of unemployed 55+ Workers

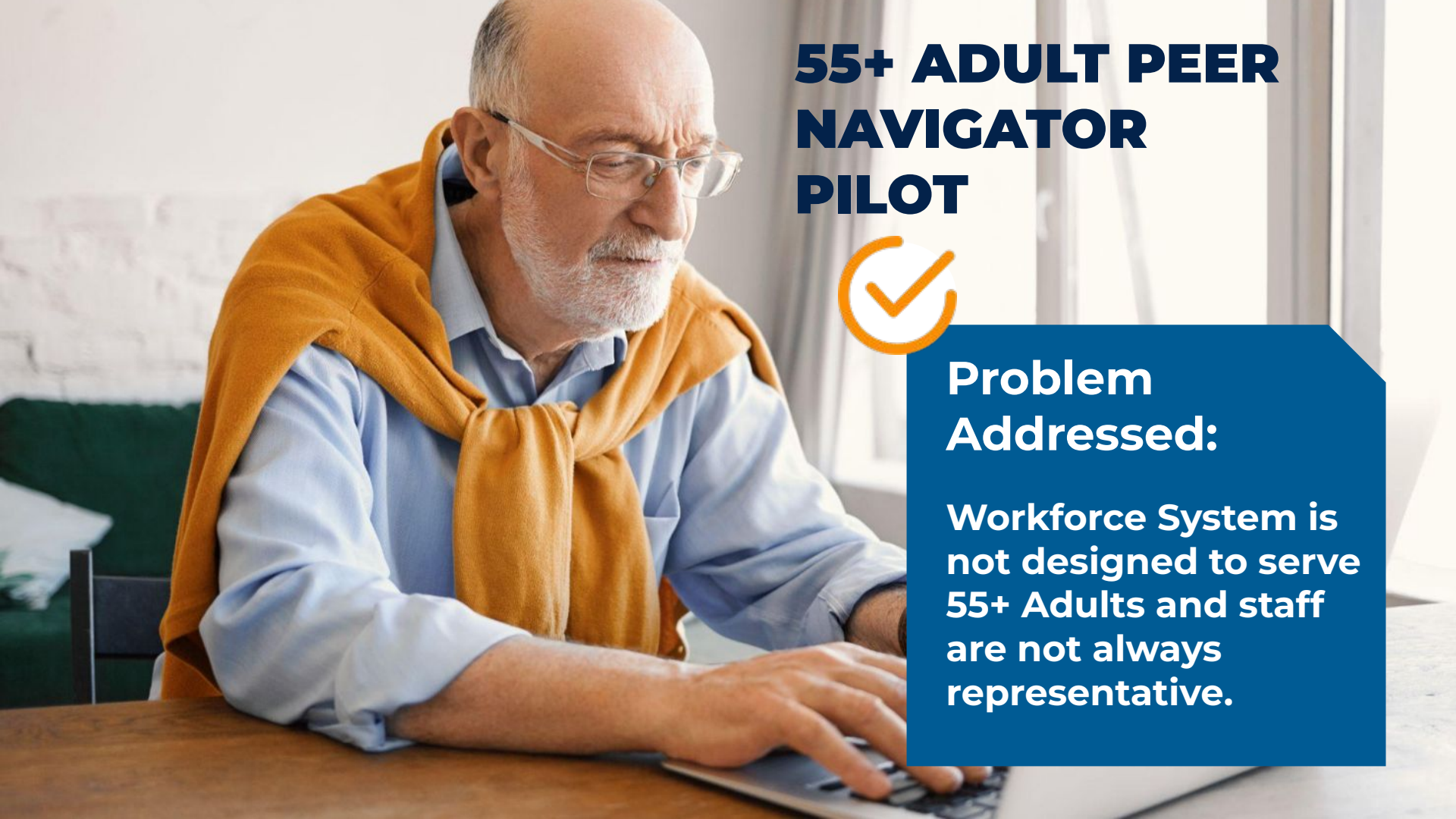
Proportion of Individuals Unemployed vs Served by the Public Workforce System, by Age Group (2019–2023)



SAMPLE METRICS FOR ADULTS 55+

- **Ages of barrier populations.** (Dislocated Workers, Housing insecure, Low-income, Veteran, etc.)
- **# and % of adults 55+ employment placement**
- **# and % of adults 55+ earning credentials & in earn-and-learn opportunities**
- **Earning change for adults 55+**
- **Industry placement diversity** (services, programs, credentials)

Compare these metrics with those of younger adults to assess any disparity.



55+ ADULT PEER NAVIGATOR PILOT

Problem Addressed:

Workforce System is not designed to serve 55+ Adults and staff are not always representative.

55+ PEER NAVIGATOR PILOT

5 AJCCs have a 55+ Peer Navigator

Peer Navigators serve 4 primary functions:

1. **1:1 Peer Support and Case Management**
2. **Workforce Navigation and Referrals**
3. **Systems Improvement**
4. **Community Outreach**



Peer Navigators leverage their lived experience navigating career transitions, ageism, workforce systems, retirement decisions, caregiving responsibilities, technology barriers, and employment challenges **to build trust and support participants.**



AARP® +



Rethinking Age at Work Training

Established collaboration to provide training & resources to employers about age awareness & engagement in the workplace

- LA Area Chamber of Commerce
- LA City Departments
- Hospital Association of Southern California

Key learning: Lead with an

ASSET-BASED APPROACH

STRENGTHS OF HAVING 55+ WORKERS IN THE WORKPLACE

- ★ Less turnover and longer average tenure than younger employees
- ★ Highly motivated and engaged in work
- ★ Cross-sector experience
- ★ Hold and can share institutional knowledge
- ★ Strong interpersonal skills
- ★ Experienced Problem Solvers
- ★ Can mentor younger workers
- ★ Increase team cohesion and overall productivity



STRENGTHENING SENIOR CARE TALENT PIPELINE

Collaborating with the California Assisted Living Association (CALA) to strengthen collaboration between Senior Care employers and the workforce system.

The senior living industry employs outsized amount of adults 55+.

- Senior Care is a **quickly growing sector** across CA.
- They are the **largest employer of those 55+.**

Problems Addressed:

- **Lack of employer partnerships and direct placement sites**
- **Focus on young adults and high turnover**

STRENGTHENING SENIOR CARE TALENT PIPELINE

- Hosted employer roundtable to learn about employer needs
- Launching the Valley Senior Care Workforce Collaborative

Help Employers Access Workforce Resources

- Recruitment, screening, referrals & hiring events
- On-the-job training & wage reimbursement
- Training and upskilling for new & current employees
- Credential, licensing & supportive-service assistance

Bring Employer Voice Into Workforce Solutions

- Identify **hiring needs, hard-to-fill positions and skill gaps**
- Address recruitment, onboarding, retention & supervision challenges
- Identify opportunities to **upskill and advance incumbent workers**
- Help partners align programs and training with **real employer needs**


PLANNING TIME:
Small Group
Activity

SMALL GROUP ACTIVITY

Fill Out Checklist: Are My Services Age-Inclusive?

Then, in small groups reflect on the following questions:

- What does your organization do well when serving adults 55+?
- What could be improved for adults 55+ to successfully navigate your workforce system and get connected to a quality job and/or training?



CASE STUDY: GOODWILL SOCAL

Goodwill Southern California Mission: Since 1916, Goodwill Southern California's mission has been to *Transform Lives Through the Power of Work*. We serve individuals with disabilities and disadvantages by providing education, training, work experience and job placement services.

How Goodwill SoCal Serves and Uplift Adults 55+

- **Career Services**
- **Older Worker Peer Navigator Pilot** (One of 5 AJCCs)
- **Early Career Education Student Advancement Program Plus** (ECE SAP+) 50+ Program

GOODWILL SOCAL
Employer Insight + Specialized Workforce Expertise

EXPERIENCE AS AN EMPLOYER AND SOCIAL ENTERPRISE

21% of GSC's current workforce is age 55+

EMPLOYER PERSPECTIVE
Reentering the workforce, retention, and advancement
Employee perspectives inform age-inclusive practices

EXPERIENCE REDUCING BENEFITS-RELATED BARRIERS

SSA TICKET TO WORK EMPLOYMENT NETWORK
Benefits counseling through certified Work Incentives Practitioner reduces fear of losing benefits before achieving job stability

EXPERIENCE SERVING POPULATIONS WITH INTERSECTING BARRIERS

DECADES OF SPECIALIZED WORKFORCE EXPERIENCE
Extensive portfolio beyond City and County AJCC operations
Veterans - Individuals with disabilities - Reentry/justice-involved - People experiencing homelessness - Long-term unemployed and unemployed adults - other priority populations



KEY LEARNINGS & RECOMMENDATIONS

KEY LEARNING

COLLABORATION IS KEY!

- ✔ **This work cannot be done with programs alone.** It takes policy and programmatic changes.

- ✔ **CA Master Plan on Aging (MPA) sets the blueprint but does not necessarily have dedicated funding for implementation.** (So collaboration is essential.)



KEY LEARNING

CULTURE SHIFT

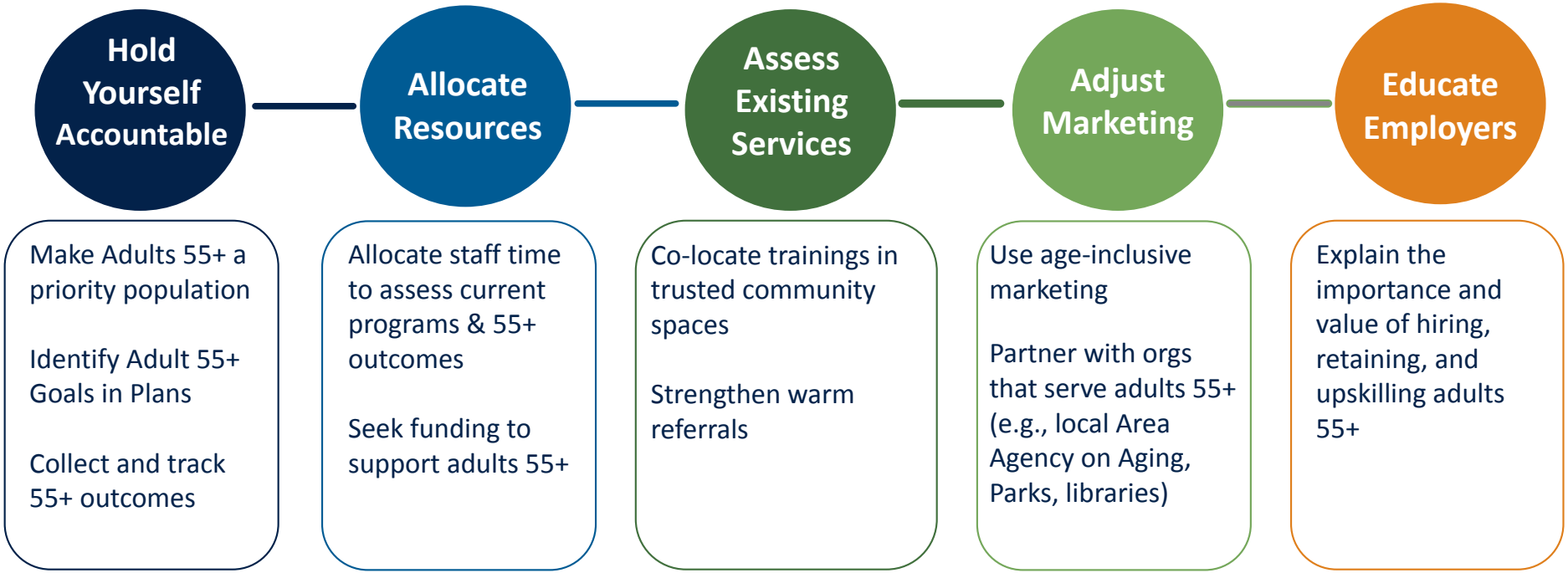
Combating ageism and building support for employing, retaining, and advancing 55+ Workers requires changing mindsets, systems, & practices.

Don’t underestimate the importance of **marketing and communications** in systems change and culture shift!

- Social media pushes
- Conference presentations & thought leadership
- Training workforce practitioners, employers, and partners
- Building champions across sectors
- Emphasizing the intergenerational connection



RECOMMENDATIONS




Q
A



TAKEAWAYS & CLOSING



What is one thing you will do after today's session to build a more age-inclusive workforce system?



Who is another partner you will engage in this work?



What data or research do you need to get more information and fill gaps in your understanding?

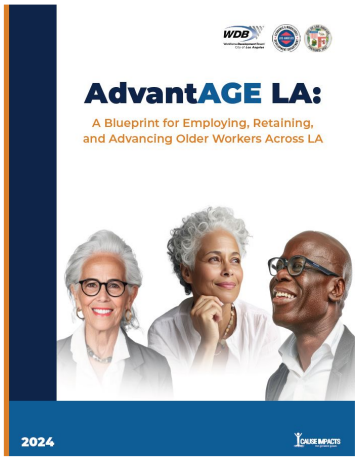
RESOURCES

Use the goals, strategies and tactics of the **AdvantAGE LA Plan** as a menu of opportunities and do something! (Starts p. 50)

Explore the **"How to Serve 55+ Workers Effectively"** toolkit

Check out **AARP's Employer Alliance**.

Access AdvantAGE LA Resources:



THANK YOU

Hannah Lee
City of Los Angeles WDB
hannah.x.lee@lacity.org

Jessica Daugherty
Cause IMPACTS Consulting
jessica@causeimpacts.com

Jorge Marquez
Goodwill Southern California
jmarquez@goodwillsocal.org

Sophia Jimenez
Cause IMPACTS Consulting
sophia@causeimpacts.com

WDB
Workforce Development Board
City of Los Angeles

CITY OF LOS ANGELES FOUNDED 1781

goodwill Goodwill Southern California

CAUSE IMPACTS for greater good.

APPENDIX

THE CITY OF LOS ANGELES

Workforce Development Board

The City of Los Angeles Workforce Development Board (WDB) is the strategic, policymaking, and oversight body for workforce services.

Our Mission

To build an inclusive, integrated, and innovative workforce system that connects talent to opportunity, drives economic growth, and ensures equitable access to high-quality, living-wage jobs and career pathways for individuals and employers.

Workforce Development System

The Community Investment Department (CID) administers ≈$100 million in workforce funds and 50+ workforce programs through 28 American Job Centers:

business

14 WorkSource Centers - Ages 18+

groups

14 YouthSource Centers - Ages 14-24

A PATH FORWARD: LA's 5-YEAR WORKFORCE DEVELOPMENT STRATEGIC PLAN

In 2025, the City launched a **5-Year Workforce Development Strategic Plan**, which aims to **place 50,000 Angelenos into high-quality, living-wage jobs**, registered apprenticeships, paid work experiences and training as critical pathways to economic stability and success.

Strategic Goals:

1. Create and expand access to living-wage jobs and career pathways,
2. Remove barriers to employment and priority populations, and
3. Implement training programs to prepare residents for work in high-growth and in-demand sectors.

Prioritizes High-Barrier Populations:

- People experiencing homelessness
- People with disabilities
- Opportunity Youth
- 55+ Workers
- Justice-Involved Individuals
- Veterans
- LGBTQIA+ Individuals
- Low-Income Individuals
- Long-Term Unemployed
- People with limited English-language proficiency

CHALLENGES FACED BY 55+ WORKERS



Ageism 78% of 55+ Workers say they have seen or experienced age discrimination at work



Balancing caregiving responsibilities with work. 1 out of every 4 employees over the age of 50 serves as a family caregiver.



Increased health limitations and disabilities. ~ 1/3 of the City's 55+ Adult population and 11% of current 55+ Workers are living with a disability.



Skills and knowledge gaps make it challenging to find employment.



Provided fewer training and advancement opportunities.



Benefits cliff. 55+ Workers struggle to find part-time work that won't influence retirement or public benefits received.

Age discrimination compounds with other forms of discrimination to create greater disadvantage. 55+ women and people of color are more likely to work in low-wage roles and consistently earn less than their white male counterpart

BUILDING WORKFORCE STAFF CAPACITY to Serve Adults 55+

Developed a human-centered training for frontline workforce staff

- How to best serve Adults 55+
- How to transition careers and leverage past expertise
- How to assess a lifetime of skills
- How to navigate the benefits cliff

Created “How to Serve 55+ Workers Effectively” toolkit.

Plans to expand the training to other City departments that also serve 55+ Adults.

86 staff trained

